Aftermath

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/55428145.

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Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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by Utter_Immolation

Summary

They'd left her there.

or

Catra in the aftermath of The Incident

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

They'd left her there.

The wall behind her had been stained crimson but had started to turn brown, mixing into the uncountable other brown splashes that had permanently sunk into its concrete surface. The same for the floor; the surface was like a twisted sort of tar, nearly as dark and twice as sticky, pulling at her foot fur and pads.

It made sense; the wall, in a small building on the outskirts of the Zone, was the unofficial area casually used for execution. It was a staging point, conveniently on the brink of the desert looking towards the mines. Surviving Rebels would be loaded on skiffs to be shuttled to their eventual rocky tombs, but before then, they'd be made to watch a culling as other Rebels, too weak or disobedient, were summarily executed, their blood washed into the sewage system and their bodies hauled up and sent to the compost.

It was a small blessing, she supposed, that nobody had decided to do the same for Adora. Instead they'd…left her there.

Her eyes weren't open. Catra doesn’t think she could have handled it if they were. She heard that happened sometimes, to soldiers killed so suddenly on the battlefield that their eyes remained open, wise with shock.

But her eyes weren't open. They were closed, not screwed shut but almost peaceful. Were it not the location, she could almost

trick herself into thinking her friend had settled down after a bit of extra training, fallen asleep, and lost track of time.

But she hadn't. She wasn't.

Behind her, in the Fright Zone proper, she can hear the eighth hour chime. Out here, it's not usually needed; the smog was a little thinner out here and it was easier to see the moons. But either way, that meant a mere two hours until curfew. She had to move.

She forces her body to obey her command, stepping closer to Adora's limp form, several fine hairs getting left behind as she steps over the bloody floor. Her friend's clothes were riddled with clothes and absolutely drenched in red, forming a solid sheet that matched her jacket and her pants a tacky brown. Her blonde hair had turned pink, and it was matted with blood and filth.

Horde protocol meant a fellow soldier was hauled along using the fireman's carry. It's economical, and allows for faster movement and were the soldier conscious, they could fire at the enemy from their position of being hauled over their fellow's shoulder. It's the smart choice.

Catra tucks one arm under Adora's head and the other under her knees and lifts her that way, tucking her limp friend close to her chest.

When she steps out of the building the road branches in two directions. To the left, the Fright Zone proper unfolds. To the right…

For a long moment she holds her best friend's cold body and stares out at the distant desert, at the dark shadow of the distant trees that signaled the edge of the Whispering Woods. She stares for a long time.

And then slowly, with a painful clench of her heart, she turns left.

The journey back is quiet, or as quiet as the Fright Zone ever gets. There are always soldiers and workers bustling about. The Fright Zone never sleeps. But few seem to see her and fewer seem to care. A few take another look at a young magicat cadet carrying an obviously dead peer, but most either recognize her and Adora or else shrug and decide someone else will do something about it if it really is a problem.

People slow down more when she reaches the barracks, unabashedly staring at the two most infamous freaks of the cadet corp. Some avoid them even as they gaze with shameless fascination and intrigue at the body in Catra's arms. Others leer and jeer at the sight of the witch's favorite brought low. The story of the day's exercise has spread like a summer fire. Catra sees one of the today's perpetrators, a cadet from Squad C, sneer and shape his fingers like a pistol, aiming it at Adora and miming pulling the trigger. All Catra can do is growl and his squad howls with laughter as she leaves them behind.

She's puffing as she finally gets to their bunk. Adora is larger now than when they were children, and while Catra's no slouch in terms of strength, the same puberty that had given Adore her claws had also made her denser, and not just mentally. Catra suspects her bones are tougher and denser than they used to be because Adora just doesn't break like a normal human anymore.

Usually.

There's a rag and a bucket of lukewarm and just barely tucked under Adora's pillow is a couple of gray ration bars.

Catra doesn’t say anything or look at Kyle, Lonnie and Rogelio, and the trio in turn, lounging on their own bunks and pretending not to look in her direction, say nothing either. Instead she strips Adora down to her small clothes, not bothering to try to salvage anything and simply cutting the blood-soaked uniform off of her, bundling them up and kicking them aside.

Then she gently wet the rag and got to cleaning, wiping the dried sweat, blood and grime off of that unusually pale golden skin. Only then does she strip off the underwear and bra, doing her level best to clean her off without either looking too closely or letting others look too closely. They’d all seen everyone’s everything before but still. And for all of her fantasies and dreams, to look upon Adora like this felt…wrong.

When Adora was as clean Catra could get her, she wrangled the blonde’s unresponsive limbs the best she could to dress in a clean

set of underclothes. She didn’t bother with the sleepwear, as the girl was heavy and the mattress had gotten a bit wet anyway.

As the Fright Zone alarms signaled the half hour curfew warning, Catra dug into Adora’s kit and pulled out her razor. It was a rusty thing, human standard, usually given to the men but also willingly handed out to female identifiers. Adora’s had been shoved at her by Shadow Weaver when her body hair started to grow in thicker textures and quantity and Catra had helped her shave her back at least twice a month as the golden, fur-like hair trailed thick and strong down her spine, from her hairline to the small of her back.

The Fright Zone has no shaving cream and there's little time, so Catra only dampens her hair the best she can before starting to hack at it. It’s too tangled and matted otherwise, and it’ll grow speedily back besides. Still, she tries to be careful not to nick anything or make it too haphazard a cut, slicing and shaping until it’s about an inch long before wiping and combing the remaining clumps of blood, flesh and dirt out of her locks.

The lights give a warning flash and in the span of sixty seconds she hastily moves the soiled water and bucket out of the way, tosses the ruined clothing and bloody hair in the trash, pulls her blanket from her own bunk to drape over Adora’s still form and just barely has settled down at her friends feet when when the lights go out.

In the darkness she can still see quite well. She gazes at Adora’s motionless chest for what feels like an eternity before she finally drifts off into an uneasy sleep.

Hours later, she awakens, not quite sure why. She lays in the silence and listens, trying to figure it out before she realizes–the feet she's pressed against are warm. And through them she can feel a slow, steady heartbeat.

End Notes

Not a major series update, but a little bit of an insight into Catra after The Incident, which in this universe was Adora being used as a test dummy for the Horde cadets to become blooded--after all, why waste the opportunity when said test dummy is nigh unkillable and heals like nothing happened? Every cadet save Catra participated, and eventually the stress and damage was too much, which is why it takes so long for Adora to "come back to life" as it were. The trauma of having heard, then carried her best friend's dead body is something that would stick with Catra for years down the line, which comes up in "Chaos and Control".

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